B1 Reading

Skimming and scanning

Two fast reading skills: get the main idea in seconds, or find one fact without reading everything.

You do not need to read every word of every text. **Skimming** means reading quickly for the general idea. **Scanning** means searching for one specific piece of information, such as a name, a date or a price.

Skill	When to use it	How
Skimming	To decide if a text is useful, or to get the main idea before reading in detail	Read the title, the first and last paragraphs, and the first sentence of each paragraph.
Scanning	To answer a question about one detail	Decide what the answer looks like (a number, a name, a day), then move your eyes down the page looking only for that.

Text

Riverside Library: new opening hours

From 1 March, Riverside Library will open earlier on weekdays. The doors will open at 8 am instead of 9 am, from Monday to Friday, so that students can study before school and work.

On Saturdays the library will stay open until 6 pm, one hour later than now. It will still be closed on Sundays.

The library is also starting a free conversation club for people learning English. It meets every Wednesday at 7 pm in Room 2. You do not need to book; just come along.

Look for signals. Numbers, capital letters and words like *every*, *from* and *until* help you scan quickly.

Common mistake. Reading slowly from the first word to the last when the question only asks for one detail. Read the question first, then scan.

Practice

1. Skim: What is the text mainly about? (a) a new library building (b) changes at the library (c) a school timetable
2. Scan: What time will the library open on weekdays from 1 March?
3. Scan: What time does the library close on Saturdays now?
4. Scan: Is the library open on Sundays?
5. Scan: Where does the conversation club meet?
6. Scan: Do you need to book a place in the club?

▼ **Show answers**

1. (b) changes at the library
2. 8 am
3. 5 pm (it will close at 6 pm from 1 March, one hour later)
4. No, it is closed on Sundays.
5. In Room 2
6. No, you can just come along.